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IND vs SA: India will fight back in the second Test, says Justin Langer

BENGALURU: India, once invincible at home in the longer format, have been beaten in their backyard in the recent past. Their 30-run loss to South Africa at Eden Gardens on Sunday is their fourth defeat in six home Test matches. It is a significant statistic for a nation that suffered only four defeats in home Tests between Feb 2013 to Oct 2024

Questions are being raised about India’s dominance at home. Addressing these concerns, former Australian player and coach Justin Langer put the debate to rest.

"Anyone who suggests it's the end of (home domination) in this country, they're a more courageous person than me because I would never say that, there's too much talent in India," Langer told TOI.

However, the batters have been poor in the last four defeats, mostly in spin-friendly conditions. They were bundled out for less than 200 on five instances. Their ability to dig deep and stay at the crease in difficult conditions has come under the scanner. In the first Test against South Africa, India batted for 97.2 overs across two innings, while in the New Zealand series, which they lost 0-3 last year, they occupied the crease for 324 overs across eight innings.

The visiting spinners have found success in troubling Indian batters on tough batting surfaces. To a large extent, with overseas players plying their trade in the Indian Premier League, Indian conditions are no longer alien to them.

"The greatest highlight of my career was beating India in that 2004 series because it always felt impossible to beat India in India. That was the Mount Everest moment of our career. So it's really interesting, isn't it, that we're seeing a bit of a change with visiting teams beating India in India? Perhaps it is because some of the other countries and their players are playing in the IPL too," Langer, the brand ambassador of NiviCap, said here on Monday.

With the next Test starting on Nov 22 in Guwahati, Langer expects India to fight back.

"Remember, some of the Indian players just came from Australia (white-ball series, which ended on Nov 8), where it's opposite. And a few days later, they're playing in really tough conditions in Kolkata. India have got some very good players in that team and they'll be disappointed and look to fight back in the next Test."

ROOT UNDER NO PRESSURE

With the Ashes, featuring Australia and England in Perth starting on Friday, Joe Root has become a talking point. The Englishman, who has 39 Test tons, is searching for his elusive three-digit mark in Australia.

But Langer believes Root is under no pressure. "Root has got more Test runs than anyone in the history of English cricket. He is a superstar. Yes, at the moment he hasn't scored a Test hundred (in Australia). Will he score it in the next five Tests? Only time will tell. But, he's under zero pressure (to score the elusive ton)."